

Israel and Palestine

After six million Jews died in the Holocaust (see pp.192–193), Jews sought a safe haven in their ancestral homeland. The United Nations voted to separate British-controlled Palestine into two states, one Jewish (Israel) and one Arab (Palestine). But the decision angered Arab states, as the Arab population considered Palestine its home as well. A series of wars began, and the conflict is still unresolved today.

In 1948, as the last British troops left Palestine and the state of Israel was declared, all its Arab neighbors attacked. At the end of this First Arab–Israeli War, Israel had captured more land from the Palestinians, and the Arab nations of Jordan and Egypt occupied the areas known as the

▼ PALESTINE'S REFUGEE CAMPS

In 1948, during the First Arab–Israeli War, 700,000 Palestinians were expelled or fled their homes and became refugees in the West Bank and Gaza, as well as Lebanon, Syria, and Jordan. Palestinians refer to this loss of their homeland as their “nakba” (catastrophe).

West Bank and Gaza respectively. The occupation of the West Bank stirred religious nationalism in Israel. During the Six-Day War of 1967, the West Bank and Gaza were taken by Israel, who also occupied the Sinai Peninsula in Egypt and Golan Heights in Syria.

The Sinai Peninsula was returned to Egypt after a peace treaty in 1979, and Gaza and parts of the West Bank have been returned to Palestine. But today the two sides remain as far from reaching an agreement about their territory disputes as ever.



▲ THE SS EXODUS

In 1947, 4,500 Jewish refugees set sail for Palestine on board the SS Exodus. They were stopped by the British who decided that they had to return to Germany. Protests around the world eventually led to support for the creation of a Jewish state.



▲ PEACE NEGOTIATIONS

The United Nations supports a two-state solution, with an independent state of Palestine alongside the state of Israel. The global community has tried to negotiate several peace deals. One such example was the 1993 Oslo Peace Accords, which initiated peace talks between Israel and Palestine. However, tensions and fighting are still ongoing.

